



FREE BUYER GUIDE

THE BRAZOS VALLEY BUYERS GUIDE

A plain-English guide to buying a home in
College Station, Bryan, and Aggieland

PRE-APPROVAL • HOME SEARCH • OFFER • CLOSING

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Start Here: Your Roadmap to Homeownership

Buying a home is a series of manageable decisions. This guide explains the process, what you will need to prepare, and how I will help you navigate the details that commonly surprise buyers in the Bryan-College Station market.

The big idea

The strongest buyers do three things early: set a comfortable monthly budget, choose a local team they trust, and protect cash for the costs that show up after the offer is accepted.

1	Prepare	Review credit, savings, monthly obligations, and your target payment.
2	Get pre-approved	Compare lenders and receive a pre-approval based on verified finances.
3	Build the search with your agent	I help narrow areas, priorities, property types, and total monthly cost.
4	Tour and evaluate together	We compare condition, layout, resale factors, maintenance needs, and value.
5	Build and submit a smart offer	I analyze the market, prepare the offer, explain deadlines, and negotiate terms.
6	Coordinate due diligence	I track the option period, help coordinate inspections, and organize next steps.
7	Manage contract to close	I coordinate with the lender,

		title team, appraiser, and seller's agent.
8	Walk-through, closing, and keys	We verify condition, resolve final questions, and prepare you for possession.

How Much Home Can You Actually Afford?

A lender may approve a number that is higher than the payment you will enjoy living with. Start with the monthly payment you can comfortably carry, then work backward to a price range.

Build your true monthly housing number

- Principal and interest on the mortgage
- Property taxes, which vary by property and taxing jurisdictions
- Homeowners insurance and any required flood or wind coverage
- Homeowners association dues, if applicable
- Utilities, routine maintenance, and a repair reserve
- Private mortgage insurance or other loan-specific costs, when applicable

Comfort test

After estimating the full payment, ask: Can I still save for emergencies, retirement, travel, vehicle repairs, and normal life? A technically approvable payment is not always a comfortable payment.

Cash to plan for before closing

Cost category	What it covers
Earnest money	Good-faith deposit delivered according to the contract.
Option fee	Pays for the negotiated option period in a typical Texas resale contract.
Inspection and specialty evaluations	Often paid directly to inspectors at the time of service.
Appraisal	Usually ordered through the lender and commonly paid before closing.
Down payment	Varies by loan program and buyer strategy.
Closing costs and prepaid	May include lender, title, insurance, escrow, and other transaction costs.

Cost category	What it covers
items	
Move-in reserve	Cash for movers, utilities, immediate repairs, furnishings, and surprises.

Pre-Approval: The Step That Makes Everything Easier

A solid pre-approval gives us a realistic price range and lets me structure an offer that matches your financing. I can connect you with local lenders, help you compare the questions that matter, and keep the lender informed once we find the right home.

What a lender may request

- Recent income documentation and employment history
- Bank and asset statements
- Permission to review credit
- Identification and residential history
- Information about debts, support obligations, or other real estate owned

Questions worth asking every lender

- What loan options fit my down payment, credit profile, and expected ownership timeline?
- What is the estimated total monthly payment at several price points?
- Which fees are lender-controlled, and which are third-party estimates?
- Can I compare the interest rate and annual percentage rate on a written Loan Estimate?
- How quickly can your team close, and who will communicate with me during underwriting?
- Are there any actions I should avoid before closing?

Protect your approval

Before closing, avoid opening new credit, financing furniture or a vehicle, moving large amounts of money without documentation, changing jobs without speaking to the lender, or missing payments.

Neighborhoods and Commutes Around Texas A&M

There is no single “best” area. I will help you compare neighborhoods based on commute, lot size, home age, school preferences, lifestyle, resale considerations, and whether you value walkability or a quieter suburban setting.

Near campus / central College Station

Shorter access to Texas A&M and established amenities; evaluate traffic, student-rental concentration, parking, and game-day patterns.

South College Station

Newer subdivisions and retail growth; compare commute routes, future development, and HOA rules.

West College Station / Wellborn corridor

A mix of subdivisions and semi-rural options; verify utilities, road access, and planned development.

Central Bryan

Historic character, local restaurants, and older housing stock; pay close attention to systems, drainage, foundations, and renovation quality.

West and north Bryan

Established neighborhoods and newer construction; compare property taxes, commute, and access to major roads.

Outside the core cities

Potential for more land and privacy; investigate septic, wells, internet, floodplain, road maintenance, and deed restrictions.

Drive the commute yourself

Test the route at the time you would normally travel. Around Texas A&M, class schedules, major events, construction, and train crossings can change the feel of a commute.

Tour Homes Like a Future Owner

A beautiful kitchen can distract from the expensive parts of a house. At each showing, I will help you evaluate lifestyle fit, visible condition, resale factors, and the questions that deserve deeper investigation.

Look beyond finishes

Inside the home	Outside and around the property
• Age and apparent condition of HVAC, water heater, roof, windows, and appliances	• Grading and where water flows during heavy rain
• Signs of moisture, movement, patching, or recurring cracks	• Tree condition and proximity to the structure
• Water pressure, drainage at fixtures, and visible plumbing materials	• Driveway, fences, exterior masonry, siding, and drainage systems
• Electrical panel, outlets, and obvious do-it-yourself work	• Neighboring property uses, road noise, parking, and traffic
• Storage, furniture layout, natural light, noise, and room function	• Sun exposure, yard maintenance, utilities, easements, and HOA restrictions
Red flag does not always mean “walk away” It means slow down, gather qualified information, estimate cost and risk, and decide whether the price and contract terms still make sense.	

Writing an Offer That Fits the Property

The strongest offer is not always the highest price. I will review comparable sales, current competition, property condition, and the seller's priorities, then help you build an offer that balances price, timing, financing, and protection.

Major offer decisions

- Offer price and how it compares with recent nearby sales and active competition
- Earnest money and option fee amounts
- Length of the option period and inspection timing
- Financing terms, appraisal considerations, and lender timeline
- Requested seller contributions, repairs, or other concessions
- Closing date, possession, leaseback, and personal property
- Any addenda needed for an HOA, septic system, flood area, sale contingency, or other property-specific issue

Texas representation changed in 2026

Texas rules and required notices changed for buyer and tenant representation beginning January 1, 2026. Before receiving brokerage advice or services, make sure you understand whether and how the broker represents you, and review any written agreement carefully.

Before you sign

- I will review the key blanks, dates, and deadlines with you
- I will explain what money is due, to whom, and by when
- We will identify the protections in the offer and the deadlines tied to them
- Ask me about any transaction language or process that is unclear
- I will stay within the real estate license holder's role and recommend an attorney whenever legal advice or custom legal language is needed

Inspection, Due Diligence, and the Option Period

The option period is your main opportunity to investigate a typical resale property. I will track the deadline, help coordinate inspections quickly, organize the findings, and help you evaluate repair, credit, price, or termination options allowed by the contract.

Common evaluations to consider

- General home inspection by a licensed Texas inspector
- Wood-destroying insect inspection
- Foundation or structural evaluation when conditions warrant
- Roofing, HVAC, plumbing, electrical, chimney, pool, or septic specialists
- Sewer scope for certain ages, materials, or symptoms
- Survey and title review for boundaries, easements, and restrictions
- Insurance availability and claims-related questions through your insurance professional
- Flood map, drainage history, and site-specific water flow

Inspection reports are not repair lists

Focus first on safety, structural performance, water intrusion, major systems, insurability, and costly near-term items. Cosmetic imperfections may still matter, but they should not crowd out the big risks.

Your choices after due diligence

Depending on the contract and timing, you may accept the property, seek a repair or financial solution, or terminate under an available contractual right. I will help you compare the practical options, prepare the necessary real estate documents, and keep the negotiation moving; legal questions belong with an attorney.

Taxes, Insurance, HOAs, and Other Local Costs

Two homes with the same price can have very different monthly costs. Verify each property individually rather than relying on a broad neighborhood estimate.

Property taxes

Review the property record and applicable taxing jurisdictions. Appraised value, exemptions, and tax rates can change, and a prior owner's bill may not predict yours.

Homeowners insurance

Shop early. Roof age, prior claims, replacement cost, distance to fire protection, and property features can affect availability and price.

Flood risk

Check official flood information and discuss coverage with an insurance professional. Flooding can occur outside mapped high-risk areas.

HOA or POA

Review dues, resale documents, rules, architectural controls, pending assessments, and rental restrictions.

Utilities

Confirm providers, average usage when available, irrigation, gas or propane, and any septic or well obligations.

Maintenance

A practical annual reserve depends on age and condition. Newer does not mean maintenance-free; older does not automatically mean poor value.

From Contract to Closing Day

After the contract is signed, I help coordinate the moving parts among your lender, title company, inspectors, insurance provider, appraiser, and the other side of the transaction. I will track deadlines, follow up on open items, and keep you informed through closing.

A typical closing timeline

Immediately	Deliver required contract funds, schedule inspections, send the contract to the lender, and begin insurance shopping.
Early in the process	Complete inspections and due diligence; lender orders appraisal; title work and HOA documents are reviewed.
During underwriting	Provide updated documents quickly, explain unusual deposits, and avoid financial changes.
Before closing	Review the Closing Disclosure, confirm funds and wiring procedures by a trusted phone number, and schedule the final walk-through.
Closing day	Sign documents, provide verified funds, wait for funding, and receive possession according to the contract.

Wire fraud warning

Never rely on emailed wiring instructions without independently verifying them using a trusted phone number. Criminals may impersonate real estate, title, or lender contacts.

Final walk-through

- Confirm the home is in the expected condition
- Verify negotiated repairs or items that were to remain
- Check that belongings and trash have been removed as agreed
- Test key fixtures and confirm utilities are on
- Report unexpected changes before signing

Your Buyer Checklist

☐ Before shopping

Set a comfortable monthly payment; preserve emergency savings; choose a lender; obtain pre-approval; choose representation; list must-haves and deal-breakers.

☐ While touring

Track total monthly cost; test commute; review resale factors; compare condition; note major systems; avoid falling in love before the numbers work.

☐ Before offering

Review my market analysis; choose price and terms; understand deadlines and funds; select inspection and financing protections; confirm your maximum risk.

☐ Under contract

Deliver money on time; complete inspections; shop insurance; respond to the lender; review the title and HOA items I flag; avoid new debt.

☐ Before closing

Review the Closing Disclosure; confirm verified wiring instructions; arrange utilities; complete final walk-through; bring required identification.

☐ After closing

Secure documents; change locks and codes; apply for eligible exemptions; update mailing address; create a maintenance calendar and emergency reserve.

Ready to Make a Plan?



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A clear first conversation can answer:

- What price range feels comfortable?
- Which Bryan-College Station areas fit your routine and budget?
- What should we do now to make you offer-ready?
- How will I help you evaluate homes, offers, deadlines, and major risks?

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Your Trusted Guide to Brazos Valley Real Estate

Helpful official resources

- Consumer Financial Protection Bureau - Buying a House tools, Loan Estimate and Closing Disclosure explainers
- Texas Real Estate Commission - consumer forms, standard contract information, and 2026 representation guidance
- Brazos Central Appraisal District - property records, appraisal information, exemptions, and adopted tax rates
- Your lender, title company, insurance professional, inspector, tax adviser, and attorney for advice within their fields

Important notice: This guide is general educational information and is not legal, tax, insurance, lending, inspection, engineering, or financial advice. Rules, forms, market conditions, property taxes, insurance requirements, loan terms, and transaction practices can change. Verify property-specific information with the appropriate qualified professional. Equal Housing Opportunity.